The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Donald Trump said that the **Iran war** would be over “very soon”, but simultaneously insisted America was “going to go further”. He vowed to hit Iran harder if it continued to block oil supplies, and said his administration might lift oil-related sanctions on certain countries to reduce prices. Earlier America’s president claimed that the war was “very complete, pretty much”.

Oil prices fell and Asian **stockmarkets** rallied after Mr Trump’s comments. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, slid to below $90 a barrel during early trading. It had reached almost $120 on Monday following Iran’s effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz. South Korea’s benchmark stock index jumped by more than 5%, while Japan’s climbed by 3%, making up for steep falls on Monday.

The **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps**, the Iranian regime’s security forces, said only it would “determine the end of the war”. It also warned that it would not allow “one litre of oil” to be exported from the region until the attacks stopped. Meanwhile thousands of Iranians rallied in support of Mojtaba Khamenei, their new supreme leader, even as America and Israel continued their bombardment.

China's exports grew by 21.8% during the first two months of 2026, compared with a year earlier, boosting an economy marked by stubborn deflation and weak domestic demand. Growth was 6.6% in December. (China combines January and February figures to smooth the effect of the Spring Festival.) A growing trade surplus will irk Mr Trump, as he prepares to meet Xi Jinping later this month.

Live Nation, the concert promoter that owns Ticketmaster, reached a preliminary agreement with America's Department of Justice. The DoJ had sought to break up the firm, alleging that it "suffocates" competition. Live Nation swallowed $280m in damages and agreed to allow venues to use multiple vendors to sell tickets, among other measures. Several litigant states did not join the deal, claiming it benefited Live Nation.

Anthropic sued **the Pentagon** for labelling it a "supply-chain risk". The designation, which blocks the AI firm from working with defence contractors, has never been applied to an American company before. Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, blacklisted Anthropic last Thursday after the company refused to remove limits on its technology being used for autonomous weapons or domestic surveillance.

Australia granted asylum to five members of **Iran's women's football team**, citing fears of prosecution upon their return to their homeland. The team, which is in Australia for the Asian Cup, incurred the wrath of Iranian state media after some players remained silent during the national anthem before a match on March 2nd. Anthony Albanese, Australia's prime minister, also offered asylum to the rest of the team.

Figure of the day: 85%, the proportion of self-described MAGA Republicans who support America's attacks on Iran. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Saudi Aramco’s temporary advantage

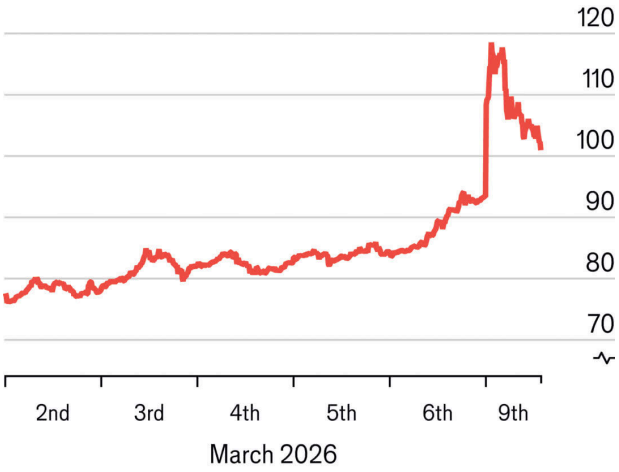
In January the head of Saudi Arabia’s state-owned oil giant waved away fears of an imminent oil surplus as “seriously exaggerated”. He now appears right, albeit for the wrong reasons.

Saudi Aramco releases its full-year results on Tuesday. But investors are most interested in what has happened since February 28th. Since America and Israel began attacking Iran, the firm’s share price has soared in the face of a severe oil shock.

Aramco is not immune to disruption in the Gulf. An Iranian drone strike shut down its biggest Saudi Arabian refinery; the company has reduced its output. But the world’s largest oil producer is better equipped to cope with the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz than its competitors, and has begun rerouting shipments via the Red Sea. Meanwhile state energy companies in Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar have triggered *force majeure* clauses, releasing them from liability for failure to meet existing contracts. For now, Aramco’s sheer scale is a buffer.

Slippery slope

Brent crude oil price, $ per barrel



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: IMAGO

Germany seeks closer trade ties with America

On Tuesday Destatis, the German statistics agency, will publish January's trade figures. In December 2025 German imports and exports were up 1.4% and 4%, respectively, from the previous month. The question is whether Germany's year-end gains carry over into 2026.

Last year China overtook America as Germany's biggest trading partner (a position it briefly lost to America in 2024). Bilateral trade between the countries amounted to $285bn, with a record deficit of $101bn for Germany. Uncertainty over erratic tariff policies caused exports to America to fall to €146.2bn, a 9.4% drop from the previous year. Germany still maintained a trade surplus with America of €51.9bn in 2025, but this was down from €69.6bn in 2024. German policymakers are eager to diversify away from China. They want deeper ties with America—even if America has other ideas.

Photograph: AP

Javier Milei showcases a transformed Argentina

On Tuesday Javier Milei, the president of Argentina, will speak at a glitzy event in New York as part of “Argentina week”, intended to drum up investment. He will probably boast about overhauling the country’s economy: inflation is down, growth is up and his government has passed stacks of legislation since 2023. That, Mr Milei is sure to point out, has created new opportunities to make big bucks in Argentina, from mining to data centres. Some new deals may even be announced.

Yet headwinds remain. There are still some capital controls in place, making it difficult to get money out. Meanwhile the potential return to power of the populist Peronist opposition at some point is a worry for any long-term investor. Mixed signals from the administration don’t help. Mr Milei’s government wants new investments but, in a recent U-turn, said it would not borrow from global capital markets to finance itself. (Interest rates would be too high, it argues.) The big event—in the heart of Wall Street—might suggest otherwise.

Photograph: Netflix

“One Piece” sails back

Netflix will release the second season of “One Piece”, its adaptation of a Japanese manga and anime series, on Tuesday. The first season—which follows a ragtag crew of pirates—was the streaming giant’s most-watched show in the second half of 2023. The protagonists’ grinning skull-and-crossbones flag became a symbol of courage in the face of corrupt power at Gen Z protests in Nepal, Madagascar and other countries last year. New episodes will be shown at cinemas in North America and Japan.

Such popularity is unusual. Western live-action anime adaptations typically do terribly: “Dragonball Evolution” was a box-office disaster in 2009; Netflix rapidly cancelled “Cowboy Bebop” after one season in 2021. “One Piece” has succeeded by staying faithful to its source material—Oda Eiichiro, the original creator, oversees the Netflix show too. And its diverse casting has been well received by viewers. For an industry eyeing anime’s vast fanbase, “One Piece” may have finally charted the right course.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

There is no greater misfortune in the world than the loss of reason.

Mikhail Bulgakov